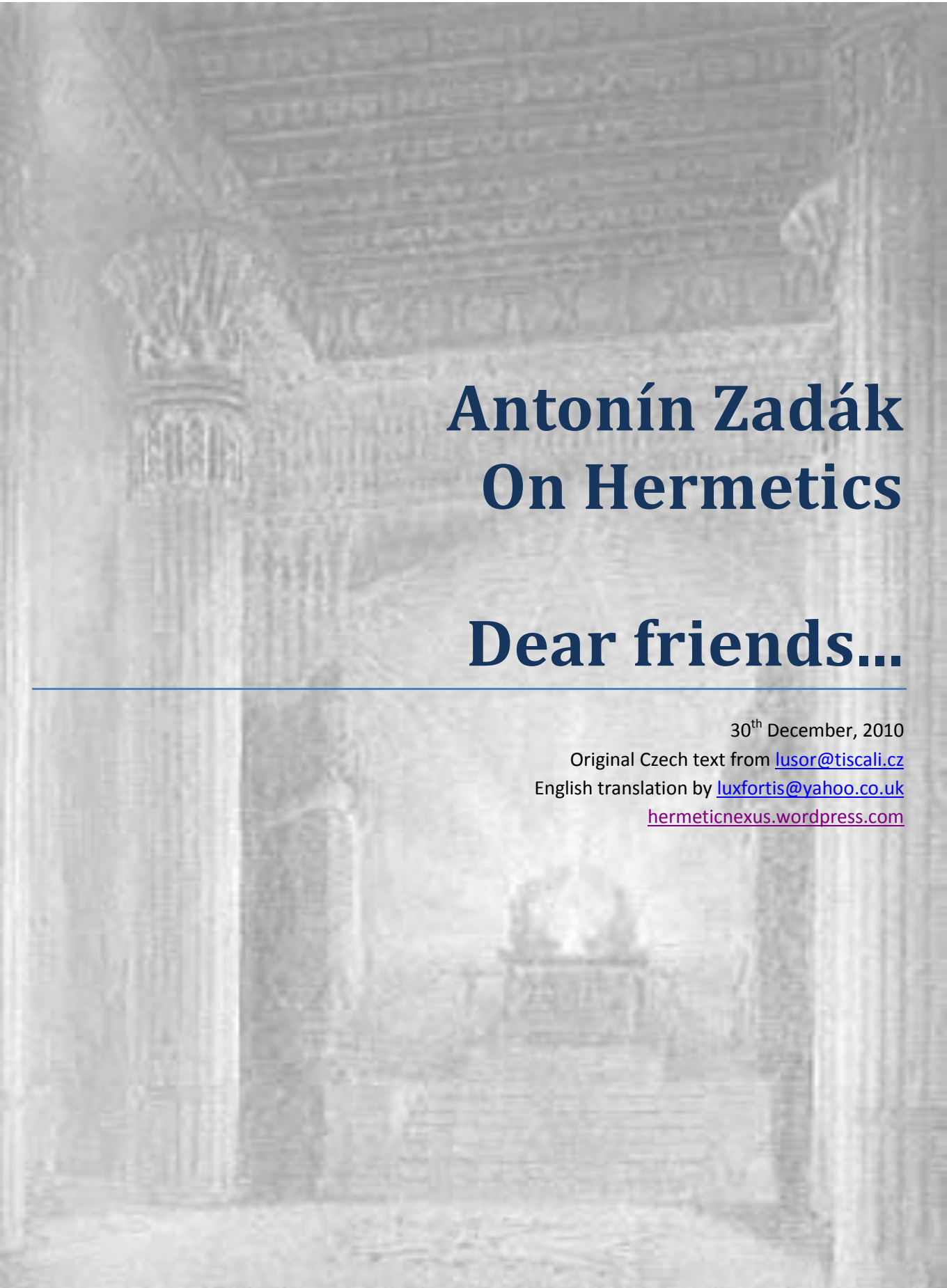




Antonín Zadák On Hermetics

Dear friends...

30th December, 2010

Original Czech text from lusor@tiscali.cz

English translation by luxfortis@yahoo.co.uk
hermeticnexus.wordpress.com

Introduction

Originally, this text was an anonymous and undated typescript of seven and a half pages, which was published in Zariatnatmikov Library (www.grimoar.cz). The identity of the author, Antonin Zadak¹, was only discovered later. The full text faithfully describes the first three stages of Initiation Into Hermetics², written by Franz Bardon. Only the sequence of the exercises is changed (Bardon describes first the mental exercises, then the astral and finally the physical exercises). Overall, perhaps this is a retelling of IIH for Czech readers/ listeners who would not have had access to this at the time (in Bohemia, it would only have been available after the revolution).

Where there are substantial differences, notice is given in the footnotes.

Comments in square brackets [...] were not part of the original text but were added for clarity.

Lusor (lusor@tiscali.cz)

English translation by luxfortis (luxfortis@yahoo.co.uk)

Dear friends,

Each of us who wants to follow the journey of the fool in the Tarot, must strive to seek and find the path to travel, leading to our improvement. We must not be put off by any effort, nor the length of the journey, if we want to eventually become the way ourselves. "I am the true way and the life", says Christ, because he followed and completed his path to the very end, and thus his personal evolutionary cycle had been concluded.

It is said that all roads lead to Rome. That's true, but it is necessary to choose one that corresponds to the nature, possibilities, and especially the previous development of each searcher. It is decisive. Suffering is the same in all ways. Either you have calluses on your knees, or hands. Either your body hurts from the yoke of your practice – our "yoke" and "yoga" have the same etymological origins – or from the gravity of your cross.

But on the other hand, "my yoke is sweet and my burden light", says Christ. How do we understand this?

Anyone who has traveled a good bit of the journey, he knows that there is one miraculous day, paid for by the burden that he and he alone must bear. This is the real secret of the Rosicrucian Rose-Cross symbol, known by Komenský³ who therefore remained unbroken despite all the human suffering and misfortune that had befallen him.

¹ Antonin Zadák was supposedly a direct pupil of Franz Bardon.

² The Gate to Real Consecration (BKOZ) in Czech, Initiation Into Hermetics (IIH) in English.

³ (Note from luxfortis) A reference to Jan Amos Komenský, better known as Comenius, a Czech theologian and educator, who was exiled from the Czech lands in 1620 during the Counter Reformation.

I want to tell you here today about one of the ways, which also leads to Rome, namely the Hermetic way. I do not want to talk here about the hermetic teachings in theory, which you can certainly learn enough from books – especially for the less well-informed. I'll ask for your pardon as this is a little personal, but because I talk about my own journey, it should be by no means unconvincing.

For me myself, Hermetics is this. Secondly it is a science acceptable to me that explains universal laws and all events in the macro-and microcosm, enabling me to decipher a large variety of religious and esoteric doctrine, myth, legend and parable. But first and foremost, it is a way which through self-knowledge leads me to control the forces resulting from the above mentioned universal law.

By directing these forces – the very name of Hermes is esoteric: “directing the effects of a known cause of action”, while the exoteric meaning is simpler: “he who gives the truth” – one can then continue on the Hermetic path to the first objective, ie. to achieve consciousness of existence outside of the physical body. The ultimate goal – ie. dissolution of the personal awareness into the Cosmic consciousness, permanent union with God – is still far away, but after finishing the evolutionary cycle of the “small Monad” – as Pythagoras calls the immortal spirit – there is the possibility to achieve that conclusion, the crowning of the Great Work.

What I can say here in two to three minutes, takes a person in question 7 to 14 years to reach the first goal, that is to become conscious of the mental part of his immortality. 7 years is the minimum duration, provided that the adept can be wholehearted devoted to their individual practice regardless of the time taken, or impact to job, family or social life, and that led to their teacher - Master. A period of 14 years is needed assuming an average of about two hours of exercise a day and keeping teachers at least for the completion of third-degree training. I will cover these steps presently, but here I only briefly mention the issue of the Master. It is beneficial and sometimes necessary to have one, because otherwise if the mission is prolonged, there can be skepticism and doubts about the correctness of progress and other difficulties especially on the various sections of path where it is necessary to work with a certain quantity of energy. Therefore, there is no need to master the mystical path, where one works primarily on the qualities, but on the contrary it is imperative to master the way of power, which belongs to the hermetic path.

A difficulty here lies in the mistaken belief that you can find the Master. The opposite is true: only the Master can find the pupil, because he knows who might just go on the way that he went on. It is necessary to emphasize however that those who seek a path to travel, perhaps travel that path because it definitely leads to a Master in the future.

But let us return to the individual steps in a reference path: the whole training is divided into 10 steps, each step containing three exercises, one for mental training, another for the astral body and a third for the physical.

I believe that this division into three basic parts is a standard: it is the corpus, anima and spiritus of St Paul; the physical body, etheric body and small Monad of Pythagoras; the elemental body, evestrum and soul immortal of Paracelsus; the body, the soul, and the immortal soul of our Kafka; the Khat, Ba and Ka of the Egyptians; the Xuong, Khi and Wun of the Chinese; the nephesh, ruach and neshama of the

Kabbalists; the body, soul and spirit of the spiritualists; and the life body, spirit and immortal soul of the Rosicrucians.

I want to mention here only the first three steps, ie. 9 practices, which will allow you to identify with them to such a degree as to be substantially influenced for the rest of your life. These three steps are to be completed during approximately 1 year.

The content of these exercises is mainly influenced by the Hermetic doctrine itself, which puts as its first element of mastery – especially within oneself – to develop imagination, which is regarded as a central divine quality of Hermetics, without which creation and development would not be possible. Hermetics assume that this ability in man is initially evident only to a bare minimum and therefore man cannot impress his imagination directly onto matter. So, for example, the architect imagines a building's construction not only in his mind, but it is also through the design, drawing plans and implementation by workmen that his imagination becomes realized in matter.

Perhaps be enough to explain, but before the description of the exercises I want to start with this premise:

Just as the Kabbalah is based on two pillars Jachin and Boaz, so is Hermetics based on 4 pillars: to know, to will, to dare, and to keep silence. First, I know, then I want to practically verify these words and I have to dare to change my ways, leaving conventional society, which cannot tolerate the variations of dissenting opinion. All this could not be addressed without the fourth pillar: silence. You are the master of words that you utter, but slave of those that you missed. The word weakens and dilutes the deed. The truly creative act is considered by Goethe in Faust, when he reflects on the importance of the first verse of the Gospel of St John: *"In beginning was the Word"* and after reflecting on this several times he finally says: *"Am Anfang war der Tat"* ... in the beginning was the Deed.

The First Step

The occult path starts with the first of the exercises of first step – the exercises of the physical body:

In the morning brush the whole body with a soft brush until it is slightly red. Brushing is performed from the tips of the hands and the arms, from the feet upwards from the side, from the crown of the head back down to the neck, chest, stomach, as well as down the back to the sides. Then take a shower or bathe in cold water and dry yourself with a rough towel until the skin turns red again, and after several deep breaths, you may add some regular stretching exercises.

Second exercises of the first step – exercises of the soul or astral body:

It has already been said that the first prerequisite to a successful start to the journey is to understand yourself and this is precisely the purpose of this mental exercise. We call it introspection, ie. calmly considering how we are attacked by the bad qualities that we struggle with and carefully recording this. It is known as examination of conscience by the Catholic Church. When you believe that you have discovered all of these qualities, try to classify them into 4 groups, which include the type of character of

the flaw, whether it is choleric, sanguine, melancholic or phlegmatic. Each quality can be assigned to one of the elements, whereby the fire element corresponds to the choleric nature, the air element to the sanguine nature, the water element to the melancholy nature and the earth element to the phlegmatic nature. Which property is responsible to this or that element is up to your own reflection, but some examples might make the matter clearer: vindictiveness, anger, jealousy, bad temper are the negative properties of the fire element, but activity, courage, enthusiasm are the virtues. Boastfulness and reckless verbosity are bad properties of the air element, but skill, joy and optimism are the good properties. Timidity, sensitivity and self-pity are the bad aspects of the element of water, whereas humility, forgiveness and compassion, its virtues. Sloth, dejection and clumsiness are the negative elements of earth, whereas responsibility, accuracy, punctuality, good endurance are its good properties.

At the beginning of your properties you will certainly be unsure about some properties – you can assign these to a separate category and then by experience, gradually reassign. Of course we divide properties not only by the element, but also whether they are good or bad that is positive or negative. And lastly, we sort the individual characteristics of each element by intensity, ie. for example by rating from 1 to 10, assigning a percentage or most simply by classifying into three boxes, where the first has the properties that occur most strongly and frequently, in the second those that control us only averagely and the third for those that occur rarely or sporadically.

This concludes the second exercise of the first step.

The third exercise of the first step

...is the mental or spiritual training and is the most difficult of the three exercises. It is carried out as follows:

We sit down in peace and let our thoughts flow freely, but watch them closely. By this we mean exactly that we must never lose control of our thoughts. Ideas must not “run” and we cannot fall asleep. We must somehow become observers of their own thoughts. If it can we do so, and maintain this control for 5 minutes so securely that we can recall all of what we have thought of during that period then the exercise is successfully completed. During the following days we will notice how our initially chaotic, fragmented and rapidly changing thoughts are calmed by this exercise and become more easily traceable.

We then proceed to the next task, which we call thought control. The exercise is performed by first trying to maintain a single idea only for 10 minutes, we deny thoughts of anything except that subject. During this time we must not think of anything else. When we see this succeeding, we proceed to the opposite exercise: during our 10 minutes we can think about anything just excluding one predetermined, usually some unpleasant, intrusive idea⁴. The difficulty of this exercise is symbolized in

⁴ This exercise is not in BKOZ from Františka Bardón.

the tale of the court alchemist of Emperor Rudolf, who was asked for the secret of the alchemists' gold. It was indeed told to him, but it was added that during this alchemical operation he must not think of a white bear⁵. The Emperor, who would otherwise have not thought of the white bear at all, could not escape this thought and therefore could not produce gold.

Dealing confidently with this exercise, we can then proceed on to the next part of the exercise and to control our thoughts in such a way as to cause their complete stop, ie. to erase entirely any thoughts while remaining quite awake. This exercise requires great concentration and willpower. Consciousness must not be obscured as in sleep, but rather escalated to the highest possible level. If you can achieve this alert thoughtlessness and maintain it for 10 minutes, you have managed the entire third exercise of the first step and may proceed to the next exercises of the second step.

The Second Step

First exercise of the second step – training the physical body

Exercises from the first stage, should certainly have become a daily practice which we will expand on through conscious breathing. After your morning wash, when you have dried yourself with the rough towel take several rounds of deep inhale and exhalations. During these initially unconscious breaths, we will now start to imagine that an idea too is inhaled together with the air into our body, for example bodily strength, or improved health, or reassurance or an improved mood. It is as if we somehow wash the inhaled air by – as Hermetics would say – “impregnation”, and absorb it into our bodies. Of course the chosen desire should not be changed until we really begin to feel the effect of that impregnation.

That is, we inhale the sense of well-being for as long as it takes to actually acquire the desired health. The first effects occur after about three weeks of exercise. Let us begin with 7 inhalations, every day adding one more, but not exceeding the number of 20 total inhalations for exercise every morning. I should also say – do not only believe that the impregnation is a mere suggestion, but that it has already been achieved through the action of the Akasha ie. through the so-called primary causal element in the element of air you breathe.

You need not only limit your idea to the air you breathe in, but also soak it in the food you eat and the liquids you drink. It is understandable that the boosting effect of impregnating your air, food and drink with the same idea of health or peace, etc., because otherwise the effect would be shattered.

From conscious breathing through the nose move on to conscious breathing through the pores, ie. the whole surface of the body. Do this in the way that in a normal breath you envisage a completely wrung sponge, which is filled from all sides and all skin pores as you inhale. Your imagination will soon become reality, and you will have completed this exercise if when breathing across the entire surface of the body, you have the impression your skin cooling during a typical inhalation, and feeling a slight breeze from the body during exhalation representing the air from your pores.

⁵ (Note from luxfortis) This Russian theme of a white bear as the subject of thought suppression is also mentioned by Dostoevsky and appears in stories about Leo Tolstoy

Perform this exercise daily along with the first exercise of the first step – twenty inhalations and exhalations will suffice.

Other part of this exercise is practicing the asana in the hermetic manner. This asana is in the typical position of the Egyptian pharaohs, as you know from pictures: sitting upright with torso, neck and head in the same body line. Legs bent at a right angle at the knees, with heels touching, and knees touching each other, with outstretched hands, lying open on the thighs. This position – seemingly simple – but we will have managed well, to remain motionless for any amount of time, but at least half an hour. During the second stage of training we will be in constant awareness of our body as when walking and sitting – in company or at home and we will try to calm and soften our gestures, but with an upright posture – just for quiet control of all minutia. This would conclude first exercises of the second step, but I would also like to add a few words about the magnetization of water.

Water is, of course – as has been said – is just as impressionable to impregnation with our ideas as air. But cold water has also magnetic, tightening effects. These effects are greatest in water of temperature +4°C. This pull-back force decreases with increasing temperature until at 37°C it no longer has any constrictive, magnetic effects and vice versa becomes expansive. This magnetic property can be used by immersing the hands, and imagining that all undesirable attributes are sucked into the cold water. The same can be done when showering or bathing in a river. When conducting this exercise with standing water (sink, tub, etc.) the water should be carefully discarded, so that it cannot come into contact with another who might inadvertently absorb these unwanted feelings. Other ways to use this magnetic ability of water will present themselves, with practice.

The second exercise of the second step – training of the soul/astral body

We now have a considerable task. On the basis of the inventory acquired during introspection the so-called astral balance must be gained, this means that all traits – whether good or bad – of each element are summed according to the previous record with a view to eliminating traits and gaining the contrary traits to achieve elemental balance. It is self-evident that we seek to suppress the characteristics of bad traits and encourage the acquisition of good traits.

How is this done? There are four options, corresponding to the four character types, but which may also be arbitrarily combined⁶:

1. Those who are most strongly influenced by the element of fire, may fight against their bad qualities through active force will;
2. When the element of air is dominant it is necessary to proceed through the intellect, especially via auto-suggestion;
3. Where melancholic transmutation is chosen - it's conversion into a single properties opposite, such hatred into love, slapdash into conscientiousness, etc.;
4. Finally phlegmatics may try the path of isolation – distancing themselves from adverse properties – so as not to have anything to do with their bad habits.

⁶ Correspondence with temperaments Bardon stated. BKOZ does not refer to the path of isolation. But it is mentioned by Bardon in Questions to Master Arion (page 45).

Without reaching astral equilibrium any further growth is inconceivable and therefore the adept should achieve this by all means.

Finally the remaining third exercises of second step – the mental/spirit exercises

And here we have to proceed to the training of imaginative skills: we must develop our imagination in all senses, and we will start visually, beginning with the following: sit down in peace and closely observe a simple subject, lying in front of you on the table (a vase, ashtray, pencil, whatever). Concentrate sharply on its shape, material, color and after a while close your eyes and try to create an image of the observed subject. We need to practice so long – many days, weeks or even months to see quite vividly that object before we and to hold the idea for 5 minutes. Of course we have the willpower not only to imagine with our eyes closed, but later also with our eyes open. There is a fundamental difference – I want to highlight – between imagination and fantasy. In the first case, images are created by the will, and therefore, consciously, in the latter case it is a morbid, abnormal phenomenon where an image or images are created autonomously to the contrary to the will of the affected person.

Then follow with auditory imagination exercises where we have to keep up to 5 minutes the auditory sense of any sound, such as the ticking of a clock, the hum of a waterfall, the sound of the drum, etc. After them come the olfactory exercises, ie. a clear idea of any scent or smell and finally the taste exercises – ie. imagining acidity, bitterness, salinity, different kinds of spices and foods.

If we are able imagine in every sense, at least for 5 minutes, any given perception above, this exercise is completed. Of course even throughout these exercises the previous exercises from first step should be repeated, especially vacancy of mind. And so I come to the third stage, the last which I can reveal to you today.

The Third Step

So the first exercise of the third step – training of the physical body

In previous exercises, we learned to consciously breathe and impregnate the inhaled air with our wishes. Also, this exercise is similar in nature: it is the entrained life force, the prana in the stream of air that you breathe. According to the hermetic teachings just as the physical body needs to air for its existence, the astral body needs nutrition for one's wishes. This prana is unconsciously inhaled by each simultaneously with their air to the extent sufficient to maintain the astral body. But by the power of imagination it is possible to suck from the air at the same time much larger quantities of prana, so that our life force grows exceedingly. An adept can not only use this vital energy to his advantage during training, but also to help other people who have weakened stamina due to disease. This is a matter for further exercises. Suffice it to say that a certain quantum of hermetic life energy is known as one "candle" and that a normal person has have ten of these units, ie. ten candles of energy⁷. If a supply of life energy falls to under 5 candles, one feels very tired and ill, when the energy decline to 1 or 2 candles a natural death at hand. For normal healthy man on the other hand, this energy radiates from his body about 1m and

⁷ The measurement of human energy in "candles" is not included in BKOZ nor anywhere else that I have seen.

therefore a sick man always feels better in his vicinity and unconsciously tries to be in his presence. Life energy of course we gain not through only normal inhalation, but also by inhalation of through the pores, ie. the whole body surface. The accumulation of life force we cannot switch, ie. we should accumulate only the quantity needed for one's own use or one's fellow men. Unnecessarily accumulated energy can cause surges and nervous irritability, which burden the adept unduly. Some adepts prefer to perform the exercises at sunrise, directly facing the sun. It is interesting to note that this energy can be downloaded and accumulated directly in so-called solar plexus – positioned in the center of the chest where the chest ends.

Because this is essentially about electricity, gurus were given to wearing a gold or silver disc at this site, which supported the withdrawal of energy. Hence we see the special insignias and later the regalia and, more recently, jewelry and ornaments here. But let us return to the next exercise.

The second exercise of the third step – training of the soul/astral body

If we have completed the exercise for astral equilibrium, we can also learn to deal with the elements so that we will gradually fill our own body with the element, and then dissolve it again back to the universe. The procedure is as follows:

We sit in our asana and imagine that we are in the center of the element of fire, glowing in the center of a red universe, which we inhale. We need to feel the incandescent inhaled air, progressing to feeling the heat in the body. Start with 7 inhalations, but with these exercises do not exceed 40 inhalations. After the set number of inhalations when you imagine sucking in the element of fire, perform the same number of exhalations, imagining the dissolution of the accumulated element into the universe. The exercise is not completed until our body temperature actually rises by at least 1°C⁸. After the exercise, however, we must return back to normal body temperature.

In the same way we perform exercises with the element of water. We feel we are in the middle of a boundless ocean of green water, imagining inhaling a mist of cold water, we feel the coolness of the whole body and the subjective feeling becomes objective. Again our temperature during exercise must drop at least 1 °C⁹, which can be easily ascertained with a medical thermometer.

During the exercise with the element of air you feel in the middle of a blue space of air, you feel inspired by lightness, your body becomes lighter from the exercises, at first only subjectively, but finally, objectively too. Then the exercise is correctly completed.

The exercise is uncomfortable with the earth element, but it must be practiced, because we need to learn to control all the elements so that they cannot dominate us. You must therefore imagine that you are in the center of a universe of heavy clay, breathe in this mass of brown clay and become so heavy that you cannot move either your hands or feet. Again, you will not forget to dissolve the element back into the universe so that no trace of it is left. And again, this exercise is completed, if during exercise you increase your weight – as your objective even by the slightest amount.

⁸ This condition is not stated in BKOZ.

⁹ This condition is also not stated in BKOZ.

If you can gradually absorb and dissolve again all the elements, this whole exercise too is completed.

Some yogis do nothing else than to solely carry out this exercise with one of the element to achieve full mastery, such as sitting down in the snow, which melts around them, or wrapping themselves in wet sheets, which are immediately dried on their bodies. Those who work with element of air, can bridge the unimaginable distances on foot, or walk firmly on water. Our practice has for its purpose, just controlling the element into the extent needed for our journey. We are told that a student once came to his Master boasting that after 12 years of practice he had learned to walk on water, assuming that the Master would praise him. But the Master had said with a smile: I'm sorry that you have wasted time you could dedicate to your improvement, the boatman will take you across the river for one penny. This means that it is essential to bear in mind the purpose of the journey, these phenomena are considered only milestones which show us that we are heading in the right direction.

The third exercise of the third step – the training of the mental spirit.

Here again we are deepening the imaginative capabilities so that we are conducting concentration in 2 to 3 senses at the same time, such as intentionally imagining a waterfall, hearing the bubbling and feeling the cold emanating from the water. If we have completed this exercise well, we pass on to more complex objects, regions, and cities which we again will see vividly for a period of at least 10 minutes. Having mastered even this exercise, we will imagine plastically before us different animals or familiar faces and people initially stationary, then in movement.

If you are successful in these exercises and finish the first preparatory cycle of the three steps, your life will be changed. You have become balanced, your mind does not swing, your judgments are sober, and your actions constitute the beginning of the path and portend its peaceful conclusion. Your health is unassailable. You find that the time you need to sleep will gradually shorten. This will give you strength and courage to go further along the path, after which you will have the Master that you are sincerely seeking, they will appear and offer you their assistance. But you will not be forced or cajoled. The path is voluntary – not directed by fate. Benefits from this journey, however, will never be wasted. It is correctly given talent, which will bring benefits to its master. Knowledge gained on this journey is lost after the course of an individual life. But an adept in a new life always quickly regains the stage he achieved in previous incarnations. He will not have to learn, but just remember, the path he joined 2000 or 200 years previously. Therefore, insist always on adding yet more every time. If you settle for very little, very little you will get, and even this little will be withdrawn.

This brief amount is all that can be said about the initial path to Hermetics omitting all discussion of the Hermetic doctrine of the elements and their function in both the macro- and the microcosm and on the three basic planes: the physical, astral and the mental, and omitting the Hermetic view of God and his creation, the universe and man within it, and omitting discussion of all other stages of this journey.

Nevertheless, I think I have said enough to those who have ears to hear, like those that I meet and whose concerns we discuss. And for those who follow any other way, or who are just searching for the path, I wish them much patience and peace of mind.

The Author